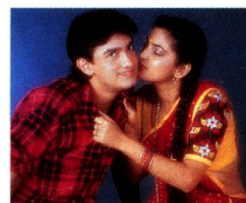


will now be taught as part of a course in film marketing at IIM-Ahmedabad. The profit he is contemplating from *3 Idiots*, as a result of a wise decision to forego his fees and split the profit three ways between producer Vidhu Vinod Chopra, director Raju Hirani and himself, will be over Rs 20 crore. But more than that, his films have consistently hit a nerve with audiences, either getting them to participate in candlelight vigils inspired by *Rang De Basanti*, treat children with greater sensitivity as in *Taare Zameen Par* or even cause them to bulk up their bodies as in *Ghajini*. In an industry ripped apart by camps, he is his own institution, working with untested new directors (Farhan Akhtar in *Dil Chahta Hai*) and even failed filmmakers (Ashutosh Gowariker, who had two flops behind him, in *Lagaan*). He's been a producer for the smash hit *Jaane Tu... Ya Jaane Na* which starred his nephew and made Rs 115 crore at the box office, a director for *Taare Zameen Par* and even the unofficial CEO of *Ghajini* Inc. He shuns the awards circus and has never been seen in public performing song and dance routines. Yet his decision to act in one movie at a time is now a mass mantra and a sure career cure. His help was sought in resolving the two-month stand-off with multiplexes last year. And equally, his move to not charge a fee for *3 Idiots* could set off a trend of stars putting their talent where their mouth is in these leaner, meaner times.

Yet as he sits folded up in his favourite chair in the projection room of his home, two floors below his mother's home where he was born and brought up, it is hard to think of the word superstar. He exudes an aura, but the room is more suited to that of a messy student, with books such as Katherine Frank's *Indira* to Abraham Verghese's *The Tennis Partner* sharing shelf space with PC games and Bob Dylan and Sufi qawwali CDs. The make-up room is stacked with the tools of his trade, from spare costumes to a wigmaker's dummy. And the terminal above his computer has chronologically labelled scripts. The actor himself is on his fourth coffee, talking about how he lost weight for his role of Rancho in *3 Idiots*, which director Rajkumar Hirani rewrote for Khan. He speaks of how he modelled the 17-year-old on the boyish director of *Ghajini*, A.R. Murugadoss, and his 14-year-old nephew Pablo, who can never sit still. He jumps up to demonstrate, as he often does in his exuberance, contorting his body like an over-active teenager. "But Rancho was also dangerous because he is without a flaw. The audience's heart doesn't go out to such a guy. So I made him curious rather than cocky," he says. Thinking deeply about his character is something Khan has done increasingly, whether it is Bhuvan's stance in *Lagaan*, with his weight evenly distributed on his legs to suggest inner strength, or Aakash's darting eyes in *Dil Chahta Hai* indicating what a shallow layabout he is. Khan thinks in close-up, wide shot and mid-shot, in total physicality, says film scholar Nasreen Munni Kabir. He borrows a lot of his technique from observation—for one scene where Mona Singh slaps him while he is helping her deliver in *3 Idiots*,

The Bold and the BEAUTIFUL

Aamir says he has always marched to the tune of his own drummer. "My choices were unusual. But when I started out, I didn't have the power I have now. I had to fight against market forces who were foxed by my so-called bizarre moves."



QAYAMAT SE QAYAMAT TAK 1988

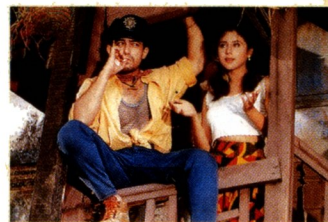
Director **Mansoor Khan**

Made at the height of the disco era, it was a breath of fresh air, heralding Sooraj Barjatya's *Maine Pyar Kiya* and Aditya Chopra's *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*. "When we shot it, I was 21 and when it released, I was 23. We would wonder who will watch the film in the theatres."

RANGEELA 1995

Director **Ram Gopal Varma**

"Ramu had four flops before this. Urmila (Matondkar) had eight. The film had no story," he says. But his loveable *tapori* Munna became the template for Sanjay Dutt's Munnabhai.



GHULAM 1998

Director **Vikram Bhatt**

"It was one of the first films at that time about disenfranchised youth. This supposed hero had such sham bravado. He was a macho guy who became almost cerebral." Khan says it took a little time for the market to understand that it would not lose money on his films.

SARFAROSH, 1999

Director **John Mathew Mathan** Mathan was unknown when he came to Khan with *Sarfaroosh* but the movie, with its tough guy police officer, ACP Rathore, and anti-terrorist theme "really shocked people as it came out of the blue". He says it marked the turning point for the trade's belief in his bankability.



LAGAAN 2001

Director **Ashutosh Gowariker**

Khan says, "When I told the late Jhamu Sugand, who was a very hardcore businessman, that I'm doing this film with Gowariker and it will cost a lot of money, he didn't blink. He never asked me are you sure? 1893 and cricket? Sports films haven't worked in India. But he didn't question me."